



the 1990s, the number of people in the world who are obese has increased by 100% (World Health Organization 2000). The prevalence of obesity in the United States has increased from 15% in 1980 to 30% in 1998 (Flegal et al. 2002). In the United Kingdom, the prevalence of obesity has increased from 10% in 1980 to 22% in 1998 (Health Survey for England 2000). The prevalence of obesity in children has also increased in the United States (Flegal et al. 2002) and in the United Kingdom (Health Survey for England 2000).

Obesity is a major risk factor for a number of chronic diseases, including type 2 diabetes, coronary heart disease, stroke, and certain types of cancer (World Health Organization 2000). Obesity is also a risk factor for a number of mental health problems, including depression, anxiety, and eating disorders (Flegal et al. 2002). The social and economic burden of obesity is substantial, and it is a major public health problem.

There are a number of factors that contribute to the development of obesity, including genetics, environment, and lifestyle. The most common cause of obesity is a combination of these factors. In the United States, the prevalence of obesity has increased in all age groups, but the increase has been most pronounced in children and young adults (Flegal et al. 2002).

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